But something was on my mind. It was on the mind, indeed, of everyone we worked with. It was to become the main preoccupation of my life at this point, and though we would continue to publish and do the work of WikiLeaks, never halting publication even for a day, the Swedish case would overwhelm the media's interest in our every move, feed a frenzy of speculation and disquiet about me, and see me in prison. I have kept my own counsel about the matter until now. It will be difficult to keep anger out of this account, owing to the sheer level of malice and opportunism that have driven the case against me, but I want to make this argument as much as possible in a spirit of understanding. I have been denied the same toleration by my suddenly multiplying enemies, and, if I cannot beat them, I can surely reserve the right not to join them.

I went to Sweden in August 2010 with the words of the Pentagon still ringing in my ears. Geoff Morell, the press secretary, had given a briefing in which he implied that WikiLeaks, and I specifically, should begin worrying. 'If doing the right thing is not good enough for them,' he said, 'then we will figure out what alternatives we have to compel them to do the right thing. Let me leave it at that.' When asked at the same press conference whether our partners, the *New York Times*, would be similarly compelled, he said, 'I don't know the *New York Times* would describe themselves as their partner . . . I don't know that the *New York Times* or the other publications are in possession of the documents.' This showed that the Pentagon and Bill Keller were thinking along similar lines: let WikiLeaks be blamed and possibly burned, while our partners who published the same material are shown to be somehow immune from the same draconian laws. It wasn't going to play well with First Amendment fans, but what Morell's words proved was that what was freedom of the press for one organisation was not freedom for another. Unlike our partners, WikiLeaks was not to be treated as a publisher but as a spy, and this absurd position came ribboned in threat.

At the same time it was revealed that there was a 90-man Pentagon task force, later increased to 120 men, dedicated to WikiLeaks and working 24 hours a day and seven days a week. The FBI and Defense Intelligence Agency were part of this group. The pot had boiled over and a number of American politicians had called for my assassination. Sarah Palin said I should be hunted down like a dog and one paper even printed a graphic of me with a target painted on my face.